aggression on our North West Frontier'. This was of course a complete travesty of the facts, but it was too late now for Auckland to change his position even if he wanted to; thanks to the hawks he had surrounded himself with, events had now acquired their own momentum.

The popularity of Shah Shuja, the document went on, was 'proved to his Lordship by the strong and unanimous testimony of the best authorities'. For this reason the British were to assist the legitimate ruler of Kabul 'to enter Afghanistan, surrounded by his own troops'. This was also far from truth. After thirty years in comfortable retirement, the Shah, now in his late fifties, was about to lead his fourth expedition to reclaim his throne. This time, however, it would be at the head of a British Indian army, for British interests, and closely supervised by British officials.

It was not by any means the homecoming he had spent decades dreaming of. But for Shuja, at this advanced stage in his life, it hardly mattered. As far as he and his courtiers were concerned this was not an unjustified, unprovoked and unnecessary British invasion of an independent country. This was the return of a king.